

QUICK REFERENCE

Demystifying AI

22nd National Academy for IDEA ALJs & IHOs · July 23, 2026 · Mark Beekman

AI assists your judgment. It never replaces it.

FOUR KINDS OF AI TOOLS

01 General Chat

The everyday workhorse: ask, draft, summarize, translate, think a problem through.

ChatGPT · Claude · Gemini

02 Workflow Assistants & Agents

Hand it a whole job; it carries out the steps and checks its own work.

Codex · Claude Cowork · Gemini Spark · Manus

03 Built into Office Tools

★ START HERE

The same capability inside Word, Outlook, Excel, Gmail, and Docs. Protections built in.

Microsoft Copilot · Google Workspace

04 Legal-Specific

Grounded in curated case law and statutes; cites actual authorities.

Harvey · CoCounsel · Lexis+ AI

THE ACCOUNT RULE

Free and most consumer plans are **not** for your role. Enterprise plans exclude your data from training **by contract** — confirm with IT before any case material.

THE PII CHECKLIST

RUN IT EVERY TIME

- ☐ **Confirm training is off** — enterprise agreements handle it; anywhere else, check the setting yourself.
- ☐ **Scope its access** — specific folders only, never your whole computer or drive.
- ☐ **Use governed storage** — keep files inside your organization's environment.
- ☐ **Organize by matter** — one Project per case, so details never bleed between matters.
- ☐ **Read every output** — no tool removes this step.

Strongest protection: redact before upload — the only method that guarantees the result.

WHEN YOU READ THE OUTPUT — WATCH FOR

Hallucinations — false, stated with confidence · **Stale knowledge** — trained to a cutoff date · **Averaging** — the safe, middle answer · **Vague in, vague out** · **Lost context** — it only knows what you gave it · **It agrees with you** — the neutral judgment stays yours

ALL TOOLS, LINKS & UPDATES — KEPT CURRENT

beekman.com/idea_2026

The full toolbox, free training, the starter prompt, and a news routine that keeps you current — scan once, bookmark it.



NOTES

CLIMB THE STAIRCASE

Don't just speed up tasks — rethink the work.

Most stop at Step 2. The compounding gains live at 3 & 4 — climb one step.

STEP 1 · ASK

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"What does ____ mean in the context of ____?"

→ a question, an answer

STEP 2 · ASSIST

●●○○

"Summarize this de-identified evaluation report."

→ a task, a draft

STEP 3 · DELEGATE

●●●○

"Build my prehearing prep packet from these documents."

→ a workflow, a deliverable

STEP 4 · ORCHESTRATE

●●●●

"Draft, then check every date and citation against the source, then flag gaps."

→ a process that reviews itself

THE R-C-T-F-C PROMPT FRAMEWORK

BUILD EVERY PROMPT ON IT

R Role — Who you want the AI to be. *"You are an experienced NY special education attorney..."*

C Context — The background it needs: what you're working on, who it's for, the facts or limits that matter.

T Task — The specific thing you want done, stated plainly. One clear instruction beats a general request.

F Format — How to structure the answer: a bulleted list, a table, a draft order, specific headings.

C Constraints — The boundaries: length, tone, what to leave out, which sources to rely on or avoid.

You won't need all five every time — but the more you provide, the closer the first response lands.

GETTING STARTED ON MONDAY

Not ten things. One thing.

One document, one prompt, one verification pass. Twenty minutes on Monday.

01

Set up right

Microsoft 365 with Copilot or Google Workspace; check with IT on storage, privacy, and data handling.

02

Create one Project

A single matter, loaded with its source material and context. Build your **Case Brain**: a master document summarizing the case, its elements, and status — updated continuously.

03

Run the starter prompt

On one de-identified document that normally eats your time. The ready-to-copy prompt is at beekman.com/idea_2026.

04

Verify everything

Read the output line by line against the original; note what it got right and wrong.

WHAT STAYS YOURS What never moves to AI: **findings of fact, credibility determinations, and the final legal language.** Those are the work.

THE ONE RULE

You are responsible for everything you review, create, and submit. AI assists you; you are ultimately accountable.

You review. You decide. You sign.

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